It is likely that the Nambudiri Brahmins came to Malabar just as the first of the Hindu temples in Kerala were being built as part of that frenzy of religious activity that saw popular Hinduism evolve out of Brahminism, accompanied by the rise of the competing cults of Vishnu and Shiva. Their superior religious status combined with their greater learning ensured that the Nambudiris filled the most senior posts as temple custodians and as royal counsellors, so that by the end of the ninth century they were firmly established as the supreme religious arbiters in the area, with their own distinctive traits that set them apart from the rest of the local community. The *Keralolpathi* asserts that they were influenced by the great reformer Adi Shankara, and it does appear that the Nambudiris followed his example in regarding the existing Buddhists as heretics, and that as Buddhism went into freefall so they moved in to fill its place, in the process declaring the former followers of Buddhism to be *avarna*, or without caste.

As their temples grew in wealth and land ownership so the Nambudiris became increasingly powerful landowners under the local system of *janman*, by which, in return for a third of the crops, they granted the right to cultivate land to *kannikan*s, mostly made up of Nairs, who in turn granted peasant tenant-farmers known as *erumpattakkaran* the right to work the land in return for another third of the crop.

This remarkable power shift – the closest parallel I can think of is the great landowning Catholic monastic orders of medieval Europe – was well established by Johannes Nieuhof’s time but reached its apotheosis a century later in Travancore.